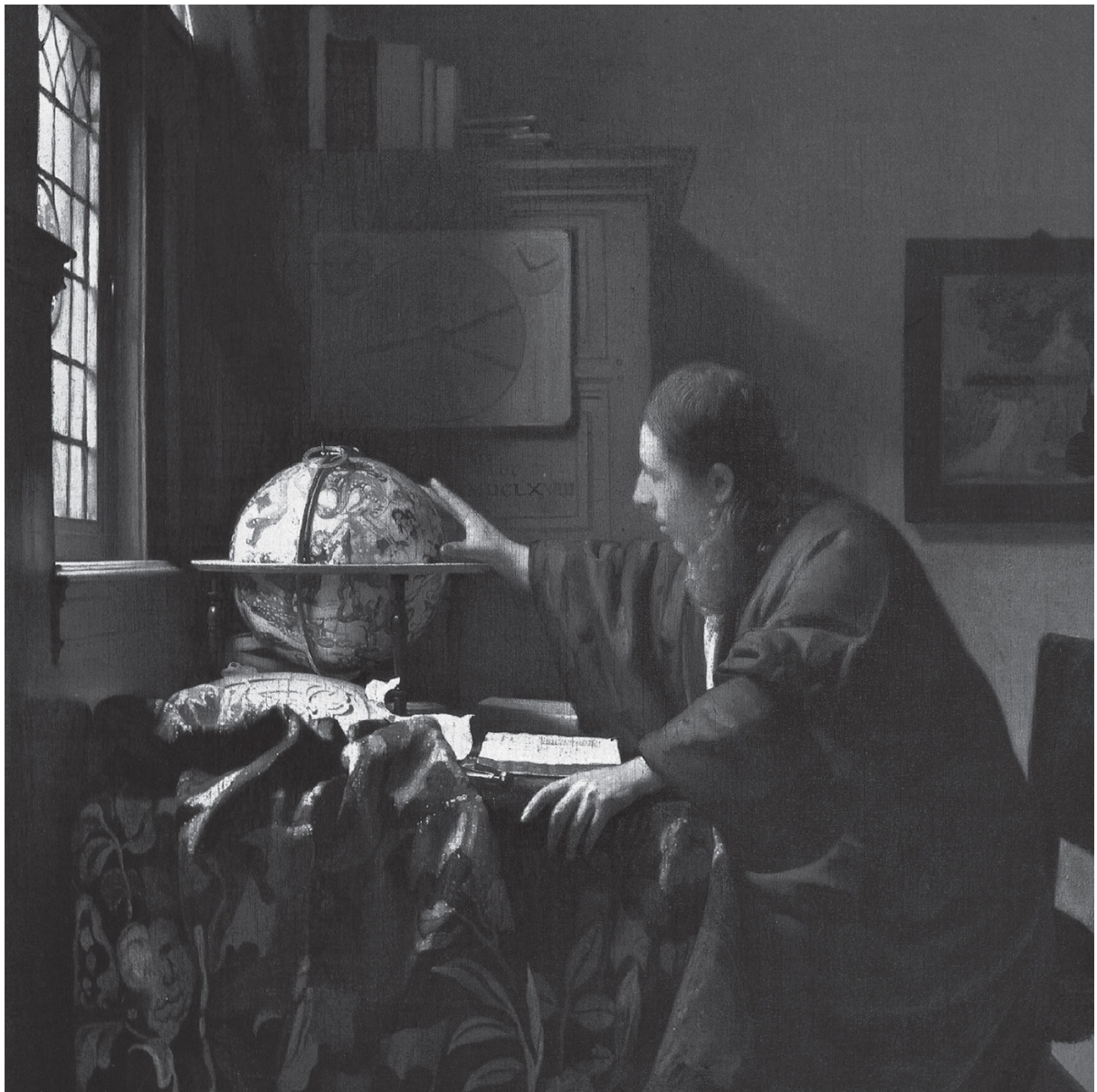


Vermeer

Only about 35 paintings by Johannes Vermeer (1632–75) are known to exist, but he is acknowledged as one of the greatest artists of the Dutch Golden Age. As he spent his whole life in Delft, he is often classed as the leader of the Delft School, but his earliest works of the 1650s include religious, historical and mythological subjects as well as genre scenes. Little is known of his life, but in 1653 he was admitted to the Guild of St Luke, indicating that he had trained for six years. Inspired by Dutch followers of Caravaggio, he experimented with chiaroscuro.

During the 1660s, Vermeer's style grew sharper and more precise, with a luminosity of light and compositions that draw viewers' eyes into the pictures with their clearly defined architectural spaces. For a while he was successful; his small, richly detailed domestic interior scenes with their pearly light attracted local buyers, but he was never wealthy and by 1672 he was in financial difficulty. He died insolvent in 1675, aged just 43, leaving his wife and 11 children in debt.



Vermeer, *The Astronomer*, c.1688